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The equation $x^4 + xy + x + 4y^3 - 1 = 0$ has no integer solutions

Size $h = 55$, length $l = 12$

Theorem 1. *The equation*

$$x^4 + xy + x + 4y^3 - 1 = 0 \tag{1}$$

has no integer solutions.

The proof uses two polynomial identities of the form $H_k T_k = U_k^2 + d_k V_k^2$ on the curve (1), with $(d_1, d_2) = (15, -5)$, the fact that an odd prime p with $(-d_k/p) = -1$ divides $U_k^2 + d_k V_k^2$ only to an even power, and the product formula for Hilbert symbols. Apart from polynomial identities, which can be checked by expanding both sides, and finite checks of congruences, the proof uses only basic properties of the Legendre symbol and of the Hilbert symbol.

1 Legendre symbols, Hilbert symbols and the norm forms $a^2 + db^2$

Throughout this section, d is an odd squarefree integer with $d \neq -1$; we apply the results with $d \in \{-5, 15\}$. For a prime p and a non-zero integer N , we write $v_p(N)$ for the exponent of p in the prime factorization of N . For an integer a and an odd prime p , the Legendre symbol (a/p) is 0 if $p \mid a$, 1 if a is a non-zero square modulo p , and -1 otherwise. It is multiplicative in a , it depends only on a modulo p , and $(-1/p) = (-1)^{(p-1)/2}$ [1, Chapter 5].

Lemma 2. *Let p be an odd prime with $(-d/p) = -1$, and let $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$. If $p \mid a^2 + db^2$, then $p \mid a$ and $p \mid b$.*

Proof. Suppose that $p \nmid b$. Choose $c \in \mathbb{Z}$ with $bc \equiv 1 \pmod{p}$. Then $(ac)^2 \equiv -d(bc)^2 \equiv -d \pmod{p}$, so $-d$ is a square modulo p . As $(-d/p) \neq 0$, it is a non-zero square, so $(-d/p) = 1$, a contradiction. Hence $p \mid b$, and then $p \mid a^2$, so $p \mid a$. $\square$

Lemma 3. *Let $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}$ be not both zero. Then $a^2 + db^2 \neq 0$, and $v_p(a^2 + db^2)$ is even for every odd prime p with $(-d/p) = -1$.*

Proof. If $d > 0$, then clearly $a^2 + db^2 > 0$. If $d < 0$, then $-d > 1$ is squarefree, hence not a square, so $a^2 + db^2 \neq 0$. Let p be an odd prime with $(-d/p) = -1$, let p^k be the largest power of p dividing both a and b , and write $a = p^k a'$ and $b = p^k b'$. Then p does not divide both a' and b' , so $p \nmid a'^2 + db'^2$ by Lemma 2. Since $a^2 + db^2 = p^{2k}(a'^2 + db'^2)$, we get $v_p(a^2 + db^2) = 2k$. $\square$

For a prime p , let $\mathbb{Q}_p$ be the field of p -adic numbers, and put $\mathbb{Q}_\infty = \mathbb{R}$. For v a prime or $v = \infty$, and non-zero $a, b \in \mathbb{Q}$, the Hilbert symbol $(a, b)_v$ is 1 if the equation $z^2 = ar^2 + bs^2$ has a solution $(r, s, z) \neq (0, 0, 0)$ in $\mathbb{Q}_v$, and -1 otherwise. For an odd integer t , we put $\varepsilon(t) = (t-1)/2$ and $\omega(t) = (t^2-1)/8$. We use the following facts [2, Chapter III, Theorems 1 and 3].

Theorem 4. *Let a and b be non-zero integers.*

- (i) $(a, b)_\infty = -1$ if and only if $a < 0$ and $b < 0$.

- (ii) Let p be an odd prime, and write $a = p^\alpha u$ and $b = p^\beta w$ with $p \nmid uw$. Then $(a, b)_p = (-1)^{\alpha\beta\varepsilon(p)}(u/p)^\beta(w/p)^\alpha$.
- (iii) Write $a = 2^\alpha u$ and $b = 2^\beta w$ with u and w odd. Then $(a, b)_2 = (-1)^{\varepsilon(u)\varepsilon(w) + \alpha\omega(w) + \beta\omega(u)}$.
- (iv) $(a, b)_v = 1$ for all but finitely many v , and $\prod_v (a, b)_v = 1$, the product over all primes v and $v = \infty$.

Lemma 5. Let n be a non-zero integer.

- (a) If $n > 0$ or $d < 0$, then $(n, -d)_\infty = 1$.
- (b) If p is a prime with $p \nmid 2d$, then $(n, -d)_p = (-d/p)^{v_p(n)}$.
- (c) If p is a prime with $p \mid d$, write $d = pd'$ and $n = p^j u$ with $p \nmid u$. Then $(n, -d)_p = (u/p)(d'/p)^j$.
- (d) Write $n = 2^j u$ with u odd. Then $(n, -d)_2 = (-1)^{\varepsilon(u)\varepsilon(-d) + j\omega(d)}$. In particular, $(n, -d)_2 = 1$ if $-d \equiv 1 \pmod{8}$.

Proof. Part (a) follows from Theorem 4(i), as $-d < 0$ only if $d > 0$. For (b) and (c), we apply Theorem 4(ii) with $a = n$ and $b = -d$. If $p \nmid d$, then $\beta = 0$ and $w = -d$, which gives (b). If $p \mid d$, then $\beta = 1$ and $w = -d'$, which gives $(n, -d)_p = (-1)^{j\varepsilon(p)}(u/p)(-d'/p)^j = (u/p)(d'/p)^j$, because $(-1/p) = (-1)^{\varepsilon(p)}$. Part (d) is Theorem 4(iii) with $a = n$, $b = -d$, $\beta = 0$ and $w = -d$, because $\omega(-d) = \omega(d)$. If $-d \equiv 1 \pmod{8}$, then $\varepsilon(-d)$ is divisible by 4 and $d^2 \equiv 1 \pmod{16}$, so both exponents are even. $\square$

2 The auxiliary polynomials

Put $F(x, y) = x^4 + xy + x + 4y^3 - 1$, so that (1) is the equation $F(x, y) = 0$. For the first identity, $d_1 = 15$, and we define

$$\begin{aligned}
H_1 &= -3x - 6y + 25, \\
T_1 &= 216x^2 - 432xy - 3384x + 864y^2 + 3600y + 15000, \\
U_1 &= 36x^2 - 9x + 63, \\
V_1 &= 27x - 157, \\
G_1 &= -1296, \\
A_1 &= 81, \\
B_1 &= -108x - 601,
\end{aligned}$$

for the second identity, $d_2 = -5$, and we define

$$\begin{aligned}
H_2 &= -y - 1, \\
T_2 &= x + 4y^2 - 4y + 4, \\
U_2 &= x^2, \\
V_2 &= 1, \\
G_2 &= -1, \\
A_2 &= 0, \\
B_2 &= 1,
\end{aligned}$$

and, for the signs, we also use

$$Q_1 = 36x^2 - 72xy - 564x + 144y^2 + 600y + 2500,$$

$$\begin{aligned}
M_1 &= 216x^4 - 108x^3 + 2592x^2 - 21384x + 62284, \\
E_1 &= 15552x^2 - 238464x + 1080000.
\end{aligned}$$

Expanding both sides, one checks the identities

$$H_1T_1 - U_1^2 - 15V_1^2 = G_1F, \quad (2)$$

$$H_2T_2 - U_2^2 + 5V_2^2 = G_2F, \quad (3)$$

$$A_1U_1 + B_1V_1 = 2^2 \cdot 5 \cdot 4973, \quad (4)$$

$$A_2U_2 + B_2V_2 = 1, \quad (5)$$

$$-216F = Q_1H_1 - M_1, \quad (6)$$

$$576Q_1 = (-72x + 288y + 600)^2 + E_1. \quad (7)$$

3 Proof of Theorem 1

Suppose that $(x, y) \in \mathbb{Z}^2$ is a solution of (1). Then $F(x, y) = 0$, and (2) and (3) give

$$H_kT_k = U_k^2 + d_kV_k^2 \quad (k = 1, 2), \quad (8)$$

where the polynomials now denote their values at (x, y) .

Step 1: local symbols. For a prime p , let B_p be the set of k such that $p \mid d_k$, or, if $p = 2$, such that $-d_k \not\equiv 1 \pmod{8}$, and let S be the set of primes p with $B_p \neq \emptyset$. Here $S = \{2, 3, 5\}$, with $B_2 = \{2\}$, $B_3 = \{1\}$, and $B_5 = \{1, 2\}$. For $p \in S$ and $k \in B_p$, we write $H_k = p^{j_k}u_k$ with $p \nmid u_k$, and $p^j \cdot u$ for the class of the integers p^ju' with $p \nmid u'$ and $u' \equiv u \pmod{p}$, or $u' \equiv u \pmod{8}$ if $p = 2$. By Lemma 5(c) and (d), the class of H_k determines $(H_k, -d_k)_p$.

The prime 2. Checking the 32^2 residue pairs modulo 32, we find that (1) has exactly 16 solutions modulo 32, and that at each of them $2^3 \nmid H_2$, so that the residue of H_2 modulo 32 determines its class. The classes of H_2 that occur, and the values of $(H_2, -d_2)_2$, are $2^2 \cdot 3 \mapsto 1$ and $2^2 \cdot 5 \mapsto 1$. Hence $(H_2, -d_2)_2 = 1$.

The prime 3. Checking the 3^2 residue pairs modulo 3, we find that (1) has exactly 2 solutions modulo 3, and that at each of them $3 \nmid H_1$, so that the residue of H_1 modulo 3 determines its class. The class of H_1 is always 1, and so $(H_1, -d_1)_3 = 1$.

The prime 5. Checking the 625^2 residue pairs modulo 625, we find that (1) has exactly 375 solutions modulo 625, and that at each of them $5^4 \nmid H_k$ for $k \in B_5$, so that the residue of (H_1, H_2) modulo 625 determines its class. The classes of (H_1, H_2) that occur, and the values of $((H_k, -d_k)_5)_{k \in B_5}$, are $(1, 5 \cdot 2) \mapsto (1, -1)$, $(3, 1) \mapsto (-1, 1)$, $(5^2 \cdot 1, 2) \mapsto (1, -1)$, $(5^2 \cdot 4, 2) \mapsto (1, -1)$, and $(5^3 \cdot 3, 2) \mapsto (1, -1)$. Hence $((H_k, -d_k)_5)_{k \in B_5}$ is $(1, -1)$ or $(-1, 1)$.

Step 2: signs. *The sign of H_1 .* Since $F(x, y) = 0$, (6) gives $Q_1H_1 = M_1$, and M_1 and E_1 depend only on x . We show that $M_1 > 0$ and $E_1 > 0$. If $x \geq 8$, write $x = 8 + z$ with $z \geq 0$; if $x \leq -1$, write $x = -1 - z$ with $z \geq 0$. In both cases, expanding M_1 and E_1 as polynomials in z gives non-negative coefficients and positive constant terms, so $M_1 > 0$ and $E_1 > 0$. It remains to consider $0 \leq x \leq 7$. For $x \in \{0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7\}$ we have $M_1 > 0$ and $E_1 > 0$. Hence $M_1 > 0$ and $E_1 > 0$, so (7) gives $576Q_1 \geq E_1 > 0$, and $Q_1H_1 = M_1 > 0$ gives $H_1 > 0$.

The value of H_2 . By (5), U_2 and V_2 are not both zero, so $U_2^2 - 5V_2^2 \neq 0$ by Lemma 3 with $d = -5$, and (8) gives $H_2 \neq 0$.

Step 3: primes p with $(-d_k/p) = -1$. Let $k \in \{1, 2\}$, and let p be an odd prime with $(-d_k/p) = -1$, where $(d_1, d_2) = (15, -5)$. We show that $v_p(H_k)$ is even. By (4)–(5), U_k and V_k are not both zero, so (8) and Lemma 3 show that $v_p(H_kT_k) = v_p(U_k^2 + d_kV_k^2)$ is even. Suppose

that p divides both H_k and T_k . Then $p \mid U_k^2 + d_k V_k^2$ by (8), so $p \mid U_k$ and $p \mid V_k$ by Lemma 2, and $p \mid R_k$, where R_k is the right-hand side of the identity for $A_k U_k + B_k V_k$. For $k = 1$, we have $R_1 = 2^2 \cdot 5 \cdot 4973$. But p is odd, and $p \neq 5$ and $p \neq 4973$ because $(-15/5) = 0$ and $(-15/4973) = 1$, a contradiction. For $k = 2$, we have $R_2 = 1$. This is impossible. Hence p does not divide both H_k and T_k . If $p \nmid T_k$, then $v_p(H_k) = v_p(H_k T_k)$ is even, and if $p \nmid H_k$, then $v_p(H_k) = 0$.

Step 4: contradiction. Let $k \in \{1, 2\}$. By Step 2 and Lemma 5(a), $(H_k, -d_k)_\infty = 1$. Let p be a prime with $p \nmid 2d_k$. By Lemma 5(b), $(H_k, -d_k)_p = (-d_k/p)^{v_p(H_k)}$, which is 1 if $(-d_k/p) = 1$, and also if $(-d_k/p) = -1$, because then $v_p(H_k)$ is even by Step 3. If $-d_k \equiv 1 \pmod{8}$, then $(H_k, -d_k)_2 = 1$ by Lemma 5(d). Hence $(H_k, -d_k)_v = 1$ unless v is a prime $p \in S$ with $k \in B_p$, and Theorem 4(iv) gives $\prod_{p \in S} (H_k, -d_k)_p = 1$.

For $p \in S$, let $\sigma_p = ((H_1, -d_1)_p, \dots, (H_2, -d_2)_p)$. Its entries with $k \notin B_p$ are 1, as we have just seen, so Step 1 gives $\sigma_p \in V_p$, where

$$\begin{aligned} V_2 &= \{(1, 1)\}, \\ V_3 &= \{(1, 1)\}, \\ V_5 &= \{(1, -1), (-1, 1)\}. \end{aligned}$$

As shown above, the componentwise product $\prod_{p \in S} \sigma_p$ is $(1, 1)$. The product of the vectors in V_2 and V_3 is $(1, 1)$, so σ_5 would have to be $(1, 1)$, which is not in V_5 . This contradiction proves the theorem. $\square$

References

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- [2] J.-P. Serre, *A Course in Arithmetic*, Graduate Texts in Mathematics 7, Springer, New York, 1973.